Mission Handbook 2001-2003[1]

Where Do We Go from Here?

Luis Bush

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Where do we go from here with regard to the Great Commission? Let us briefly raise some issues by considering various perspectives. We should not be surprised to find that we have different perspectives. Not everyone agrees even about where we are in regard to the magnificent millennial moment of the hinge of history. When does or did the twenty-first century officially begin? It's like a tempest in a time clock.

We live in the midst of the great millennium misunderstanding. Global celebrations have already taken place symbolized by the drop of the one-thousand pound ball in New York's Times Square at midnight on December 31, 1999, with its 504 hand-crafted triangular pieces of crystal and nearly 700 lights. However, others were saying, "Wait a minute. The third millennium begins on January 1, 2001."

Whatever the case, the question "Where do we go from here in world evangelization?" is being asked in many places and many settings around the world in these times. This is an important question at a hinge moment of history. Regardless of the precise centennial turn, the year 2000 has served as a giant magnet for all of mankind—a turning point unlike any we have previously known. So for many, the year 2000 instills a sense of urgency spurring on broader thinking.

My thinking here represents one more attempt to coalesce perspectives of many others in addressing the issues, rather than suggesting any specific course of action. I seek to raise some of the necessary questions to be addressed rather than

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trying to provide a set of answers. We can embark on the journey by considering the following ten aspects.

1. Asking God, Who knows the future and holds it in his hands
2. Understanding our changing context of mission
3. Entering into a process that encourages broad global ownership
4. Rediscovering the meaning of the Great Commission
5. Cultivating a set of values
6. Articulating the type of challenges we are facing
7. Identifying the emerging leadership style appropriate for the twenty-first century
8. Training a new generation of Christian leaders
9. Considering the kinds of structures that can best support the push forward
10. Developing an information system in support of a response to the challenges

Asking God Who Knows the Future and Holds It in His Hands

Perhaps obvious as a first step, yet so easy to forget is that, as Christians, we believe in a God who not only knows the future but also holds the future in his hands. The wise King Solomon poses the question, "Since no man knows the future, who can tell him what is to come?" (Ecclesiastes 8:7, NIV). Since he is writing as a natural man who looks at the cycle of life "under the sun," he has left out the obvious. It is only God who knows the future.

When David learned that Saul was plotting against him, beginning in I Samuel 23:11 (NIV), he asked, "'Will Saul come down, as your servant has heard? O Lord, God of Israel, tell your servant.' And the Lord said, 'He will.'

"Again David asked, 'Will the citizens of Keilah surrender me and my men to Saul?' And the Lord said, 'They will.' So David and his men, about six hundred in number, left Keilah and kept moving from place to place. When Saul was told that David had escaped from Keilah, he did not go there."

Because David was convinced that God knew the future he prayed, and upon receiving his answer, promptly set off in the right direction, escaping calamity that would have come.

Oh, that we as God's people would follow the example of David and pray to God, asking him where we go from here that we may escape the great calamity of missing God's will for his people in the twenty-first century. God not only knows the future. He holds the future. As the apostle Paul reminds us, the future is "…according to the plan of him who works out everything in conformity with the purpose of his will," (Ephesians 1:11, NIV).

Understanding our Changing Context of Mission

Franklin Murphy, former Chancellor of the University of California at Los Angeles, would say of the new generation moving into the twenty-first century that it embraces the philosophy expressed in the three Latin words, Sentio ergo

sum—"I feel, therefore I am." We have moved from the so-called Age of Reason in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries and the statement of Descartes, Cognito ergo sum, "I think, therefore I am," to the nineteenth century and Facio ergo sum, "I do, therefore I am," (in which materialism, the production, possession, and distribution of goods became the guiding principle) to the present day, "I feel, therefore I am."

Upon retiring as Dean of Fuller School of World Mission, Dudley Woodberry presented a vision paper, "Toward the Twenty-first Century: Educating People for God's Mission." He made observations on the following points.

1. *Population explosion in the developing world, stagnation in the developed*
   By 2025 the population will be 8,312 million. Over a billion will need cross-cultural witness to understand the gospel. Most of those are in the 10-40 window.
2. *Accelerating change*
   Apart from some marginalized pockets, the pace of change is increasing across the board—demographic, technological, economic, political, and social. This leads to uncertainty, information overload, hesitancy to make long-term commitments, and difficulty in making plans.
3. *Globalization and localism*
   The accelerating change involves the compression of time and space in a shrinking world of rapid communication and travel. National boundaries and oceans are not significant barriers in the global market. At the same time there are centrifugal forces away from globalization to various localisms that seek to retain or forge ethnic or religious boundaries.
4. *Increase in secularization and religious resurgence*
   The religious resurgence has been largely a reaction to the loss of religious and traditional values that have accompanied secularization.
5. *An ethos of pluralism and conflict*
   On the one hand the shrinking of the globe and the migration of peoples have created a pluralistic world—not only in the sense that many religions live side by side, but philosophically that all are to be accepted as different facets of truth. On the other hand, beside this tolerant, accepting attitude is what Samuel P. Huntington has called "the clash of civilizations"—that is, the clash of civilizations or cultures where religion is often the greatest influence.
6. *Multipolar unstable world with end of Cold War*
   The collapse of Communism left only one superpower, but it also reduced the pressures to base political alliances on relationship or nonalliance with the superpowers.
7. *Closing doors becoming revolving doors*
   During the last decade an increasing number of countries have restricted access to missionaries. Yet at the same time such phenomena as the globalization of the economy and the Trojan horse of Hong Kong slipping

behind the bamboo curtain have opened the doors for bivocational missionaries.

8. *Postmodern society impacting but not replacing modern and traditional societies*
   The wave of postmodernism has joined modernism and traditionalism. Or from another perspective, the information age has joined the industrial and the agricultural. Yet in each case all three remain with their interacting tensions.
9. *Homogenization and separation of cultures and civilizations*
   Western culture, together with the English language and popular music as communicated through television, is homogenizing particularly the culture of youth in urban settings. At the same time we are experiencing the resurgence of ethnic cultures and the major world civilizations of which Huntington speaks.
10. *Urbanization, involving mixing and fragmentation*
    The world is increasingly becoming urbanized. With urbanization come the problems of the ghettoization and marginalization of the poor and some ethnic groups.
11. *The enlarging and restricting of women's roles*
    Even as women are acquiring increased opportunities and expectations in both the secular and religious world, they are being forced into more restrictive roles in other contexts.
12. *The developing world growing younger while the developed world gets older*
    Currently one-third of the world is under 15 years of age. A global youth culture is developing non-Christian, united by MTV, rejecting the past, and focusing on the now.
13. *Globalization and regionalization of economies*
    Increasingly economy rather than politics determines alliances, making new bridges for Christian contacts.
14. *Resource relocation with resultant shifting economic strength, chaos, and potential for interrelated collapses*
    The tightening web of interconnection of the global market means that instability in one area can affect the whole.
15. *A widening gap between the wealthy and burgeoning poor*
    The Northern Hemisphere overpowers the Southern in per capita GNP.
16. *Information and communication explosion*
    Most of the world is on the Internet, and much of what remains has e-mail.
17. *Shift in center of gravity for the church*
    A definite shift has occurred in the geographical and vital center of gravity of the church from the West and North to the East and South.
18. *Increased diversity and unity*
    As Western mainline Protestant churches have declined, the more evangelical, charismatic, and independent ones multiply. Among the Evangelicals are growing numbers of postdenominational or "new apostolic" churches.

19. *Indigenization and internationalization of mission*
    As Christianity has globalized, indigenous missions have sprung up around the world. This year the Two-Thirds World will send more cross-cultural Protestant missionaries than the West.
20. *Declining mission interest in some circles while interest increases in others*
    There has been a decline in world mission interest and activity in mainstream Protestantism. At the same time there is increased interest, focus, and optimism concerning mission in other circles.

Broad Global Ownership

Perhaps as important as the vision and values is the strategy process by which these are unveiled. As we prepare to enter the twenty-first century, we need to be wise stewards. We desire to anticipate opportunities as well as problems related to these changes. Today there is a maturing Church in the developing world. The center of gravity for Christianity worldwide in terms of growth, energy, and vision is shifting from the North and West to the South and East. The mission field is fast becoming the mission force. Increasing numbers of leaders for the worldwide Christian movement are emerging from the rapidly growing churches of the majority world.

Thus any global vision or strategy-developing process must involve the leaders from the global church. There must be a listening process through such vehicles as forums or working group consultations regionally and/or nationally around the globe. The call is for the church in the West to learn from the church in the non-Western world.

Even as I wrote this paper, the first-ever-nationwide world mission's conference of the Assembly of God denomination in Brazil gathered to coincide with the 500-year discovery of Brazil. Some 7,000 pastors and church leaders came from all over Brazil. I agree with the perspective of Jim Engel in his book titled: *Rediscovering World Mission,* when he says: "It cannot be denied that the initiative for world mission today is carried more often by Pentecostal churches in Latin America or Independent Churches in Africa than by North America or Europe."

Rediscovering the Meaning of the Great Commission

As we begin the new millennium we need to rediscover the meaning of mission, world missions, world evangelization, and the Great Commission. We have been influenced by modernism. What do these terms mean from a post-modernistic view? We have been influenced in our understanding of mission by a dominant Western church. What do these terms mean as we allow the majority world church to take the initiative, and the role of the Western church becomes that of a partner or even a servant? We have been influenced by a dominant male leadership. How can we rediscover the meaning of these terms with our sisters in Christ as full partners at the table? We have been influenced by the dominant role

of the older Christian leaders. What will we discover as we invite the emerging, younger leaders to be full partners at the table?

As in the time of the Reformation we are being called back to the Scriptures and the original languages in pursuit of the intent of meaning of the original author. We are also being called to reflect theologically on these terms. The new apostolic reformation churches are making major global initiatives. In large worldwide conferences they are looking at new paradigms for "doing mission."

For a full understanding of what God is saying to us with regard to mission, world missions, world evangelization, and the Great Commission, we need to hear from those embracing this paradigm. Rediscovering the meaning of the Great Commission calls for inviting respected missiologists like the late David Bosch to the table through his writings, particularly the work of the last seven years of his life, entitled *Transforming Mission.* Lesslie Newbigin calls this work a kind of Summa Missiologica.

From the first chapter David Bosch seeks to rediscover the meaning of mission and other key terms. He explores an important historical review of the meaning of the Great Commission. Out of the large meeting convened by Billy Graham, planned in Amsterdam for mid-2000, practitioners will be concerned with the work of the evangelist in fulfilling the Great Commission. A Strategy Working Group will deal with two basic criteria: what is being done, and what is left to be done in world evangelization. Their findings need to be brought to the table as we rediscover the meaning of the Great Commission and its implications.

On a small scale Celebrate Messiah 2000 is seeking to be a part of this process. Streams representing Christ-activity moving into and through the official millennial change at the end of the year 2000 are being encouraged to reflect through e-mail conferences worldwide—then to bring their conclusions to present at the conference. A team of missiologists led by respected Norwegian theologian-missiologist Tormod Engelsviken is seeking to prepare and present with input from the other streams a Millennial Manifesto that will provide an updated basis of understanding mission, missions, and the Great Commission as we move into the new millennium.

Cultivating a Core Set of Values

In a representative Global Evangelism Roundtable of the World Evangelical Fellowship, the AD2000 and Beyond Movement, and the Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization on March 21-25, 1999 in Hurdal, Norway, several foundational values were agreed to that provide a basis for understanding, moving into the twenty-first century.

"We are a people profoundly committed to biblical, historic, Trinitarian Christianity, with particular appreciation for the Lausanne Covenant, as well as our own Evangelical church heritage. As we consider the future of world evangelization and the life of the global church, we affirm:

1. Our common goal for and passionate commitment to world evangelization

2. Our dedication to a life of prayer and unleashing the entire Church into global intercession
3. The proclamation of a holistic, transforming Gospel, underscoring the centrality of the church for world evangelization
4. The need for a new, global, relational "wineskin" within a context of continuity and not based on position or structure
5. A manifestation of unity grounded in the partnership of equals around the globe
6. The need for a thorough re-examination of a theology of the church
7. Regional and national networks that also have a global focal point
8. The need for a more representative platform in which all members of the Body of Christ are equal partners (for example: charismatics and non-charismatics, male and female, younger and older, academics and practitioners)
9. The need for one cooperative vehicle that supports a plurality of ministries
10. Our obedience to the Holy Spirit for empowerment, guidance and recognition of leadership
11. Our commitment to a biblical and accountable stewardship of resources
12. Our decision to communicate our unity to every level of our various networks, and to the wider Body of Christ"

Understanding the Types of Challenges We Are Facing

In the context of a rapidly changing world we are faced with many challenges. These challenges are spiritual. They are ideological and they are sociological. They involve advancing the cause of Jesus Christ to the inhabited world and especially the cities and the people groups. This involves a geographical, an urban, and an ethnic challenge. In his book, *The Church is Bigger than You Think,* Patrick Johnstone deals with these challenges, taking one chapter per challenge.

The Urban Challenge. The twenty-first century will be an urban world for the first time. From the present fifty percent urban, by the end of the twenty-first century the world will be eighty percent urban. The twenty-first century will be characterized by the need for pioneer mission in the great cities of the world. The expanding slums and shantytowns in these cities have risen to one billion people, about forty percent of the populations in the cities of the Third-World countries.

The Social Challenge. Christian social responsibility was recognized and affirmed in the last twenty-five years as an essential component of the Great Commission. Among those who particularly call for social responsibility by Christians are the children. Almost one-third of all children conceived are never born due to abortion. An estimated ten million children suffer forced prostitution. Malnutrition kills 35,000 children under five every day. The number of street children has grown to 100 million.

Several other great social problems afflict us as we enter the twenty-first century. AIDS in Africa has grown to alarming proportions with devastating

predictions, both for adults becoming afflicted and tens of millions of children becoming orphans in the next ten years. Drug addiction along with the illegal, global drug manufacturing and trading industry engulfs the people in cities and countries today. The diseases of tuberculosis, malaria, and cancers are major causes of death.

The People Challenge. More than 1000 peoples are still without a viable, indigenous church planting movement in their midst with sufficient strength, resources, and commitment to sustain and ensure the continuous multiplication of churches. Various important ministries must be strengthened for this discipline process to be effective and lasting. These include researching, church planting, literature, audio ministries, the Jesus Film, radio, and Scripture translation.

The Ideological Challenge. Islam presents a giant ideological challenge because of a completely different worldview, a social and legal system that makes it almost impossible for a Muslim to become a Christian, and the growth of "fundamentalist" terrorism. Hindus in the world are one of the greatest challenges we face in world evangelization today. Buddhism claims nearly 700 million with a view that there is no God, where salvation is earned by works and life is an endless cycle of reincarnations. Other ideologies include Baha'i, Sikhism, Jainism, and Animism, along with major deviants from mainstream Christianity. All of these constitute significant challenges.

The Spiritual Challenge. We have been involved in spiritual warfare ever since Satan wrested control of the world. Two extremes to avoid are the underemphasis of the spiritual nature of the conflict and too great a preoccupation with the enemy on the other hand. Prayer makes a profound difference in world evangelization. Global networks of prayer have been raised up. "Prayer-fueled advance of the Kingdom of Christ" gives hope for the future.

The Geographic Challenge. The 10-40 Window represents the primary geographic challenge entering the twenty-first century, in that it is the geographical location in which each of the previous five challenges are indisputably and significantly more prominent. An estimated 1.2 to 1.4 billion people have never had the chance to hear the gospel. Over 95 percent of these individuals reside in the Window area. This is where 85 percent of the world's poorest and most deprived live. This region is the residence for over 95 percent of the Muslims, Hindus, and Buddhists in the world.

Identifying the Emerging Leadership Style Appropriate for the Twenty-first Century

From the current trend toward effective organizational development there emerges a picture of a distinct leadership style more appropriate for the new century. The hierarchical view of the leader as superior clouds the truth now being rediscovered that "effective group members all have leadership potential which can be realized as situational demands change."

Leadership style considered appropriate for the future has gone through several dramatic changes of late. The focus of loyalty has shifted from institution

to people. The source of energy, rather than coming from stability, comes instead from change and innovation. Instead of leadership being dogmatic and authoritative, it is inspirational, empowering, enabling, and facilitating. The leader, rather than giving orders, coaches and teaches. Instead of the quality depending on the affordable best it calls forth excellence. Expectations for associates are not for security but rather personal growth. Status does not come from title and rank but making a difference. What are considered resources are not so much cash and time but rather equal opportunity information, people, and networks. The flexible leadership style model emphasizes personal relationship over positional relationship. This is the wave of the future beyond 2000.

YWAM leader Tom Bloomer, in a paper titled "Leadership of the Twenty-first Century—Leadership Factors Influencing Innovation in Organizations" writes, "The twenty-first century leader must demonstrate the following characteristics:

1. Visionary: The visionary leader is the one who actualizes shared pictures of the future that result in genuine commitment to results, rather than in expected compliance. A vision that is an attractive, realizable view of the future is one of the greatest unifying and mobilizing dynamics that exists. It is also one of the greatest morale builders and thus a powerful antidote to staff burnout and depression. Failure of vision leads quickly to loss of identity, decision-making becomes capricious, and the organization drifts.
2. Creative: An entrepreneurial orientation, showing higher risk taking and innovativeness. This type of transformational leader seems to be one that would consistently facilitate innovation.
3. Adaptable: The new leader must constantly adapt and re-adapt the organization to rapidly-changing environments.
4. Competent: The new leaders must prove their competence.
5. Committed to the goal: Leaders must be totally single-minded in their pursuit of the organization's objectives.
6. Action-oriented: Entrepreneurs and innovators were found, unsurprisingly, to have a strong bias toward action over analysis.
7. Committed to the people: Recent scholarship on charismatic leadership underlines the interplay between vision, commitment of the leader to his people, and results.
8. Motivators: Vision and commitment are powerful motivating forces, indeed some of the most powerful that exist."

Approximately five hundred emerging younger leaders from around the world are gathering as part of the event called Celebrate Messiah 2000. During the six months preceding the event, they will be linked via the Internet, into a global dialog. They will discuss their vision for the twenty-first century and what God is calling them to be and do as God's key men and women for a new day in history. They will be encouraged to have a vision, to dream, and to put those into practice.

The combined dream and vision of the emerging young leader participants will be shared with all who attend Celebrate Messiah 2000 during a key plenary session.

Training Christian Leaders for the Twenty-first Century

Two hundred fifty Presidents and Academic Deans (PAD) representing theological schools from 53 nations gathered at the Doxa Deo Church in Pretoria, South Africa, July 1-3, 1997 to consider ways in which the schools they lead can further the goal of "a church for every people and the gospel for every person." They recognized that theological educators have tremendous potential to bless, but also to damage the church; to enhance but also to hinder the fulfillment of the commission. Looking to the future, they called upon college presidents and academic deans to commit themselves to put the vision of "a church for every people and the gospel for every person" at the heart of ministry training. They resolved to explore together a new paradigm of partnership in theological education—that training schools share their distinctives and resources to accomplish the goal of global evangelization. In considering how to train Christian leaders for the years to come they developed important principles in a PAD Declaration that included the following:

1. The primacy of missiological concern for world evangelism must be recognized and focused in the total curriculum of ministry training.
2. Partnership at all levels and in multiple forms is essential for reaching the unreached people of the world.
3. Formal, non-formal, and relational approaches to learning are to be seen as complementary rather than competitive.
4. The content of ministry training must uphold the uniqueness of Jesus Christ and the necessity of personal faith in him as Lord and Savior. This is especially imperative in the light of the increasing pluralistic environment, which has been brought about by the resurgence of non-Christian religions hostile to the advance of the gospel, by the erosion of historic Christianity in the West, and by the increasing prevalence of secularism almost everywhere.
5. Ministry training must aim to produce practicing supernaturalists who minister effectively in the power of the Holy Spirit, relying on prayer and complete trust in the Word of God.
6. Basic to all ministry training is spiritual and character formation in the life of the student, in part facilitated by the example of teacher.
7. Approaches to ministry training must reflect concern for the whole counsel of God wisely contextualized and sustainable by local and national resources.
8. Academic accreditation may serve to guarantee quality control and encourage institutional effectiveness. At the same time it should not be allowed to impede the spiritual and missiological thrust of theological education. Every effort must be made to assure that accrediting structures affirm and promote commitment to world evangelization.

9. Serious consideration should be given to the training of both husband and wife for their mutual effectiveness in ministry, and accessibility to ministry training broadened to include all who can benefit from it.

A "training in the twenty-first century" checklist—a rough draft of a hypothesis based on interviews of international Christian leaders and observation—involves a set of twenty values which could be alliterated with an "I". The hypothesis is that the more I's, the more effective the training process and outcome.

- ✓ Intentional — training with a purpose to fulfill the Great Commission and to serve as a seedbed for leadership development in the Christian world movement
- ✓ Individually selective — to faithful people, receiving leaders "in the making"
- ✓ Indispensable — using a biblical core of curriculum and a commitment to the Word of God and truth
- ✓ Instructional — teaching has happened when the student has learned
- ✓ Inspirational — anointing, life giving, enthusiastically delivered
- ✓ Intuitive — knowing, perceiving, and relating to Christ. "You search the Scriptures, because you think that in them you have eternal life; and it is these that bear witness of Me; and you are unwilling to come to Me, that you may have life." (John 5:9-40, NASB)
- ✓ Incarnational — modeling. "…As the Father has sent me, I am sending you" (John 20:21, NIV). "…Christ…leaving you an example, that you should follow in his steps" (1 Peter 2:21, NIV).
- ✓ Impartation — imparting of skills for ministry, mentoring, and using the Jesus-style of leadership development (he practiced it himself, he did it with them, he had them do it).
- ✓ Interactive — not only communicating one way, but increasing participation by students
- ✓ Information — transmission regarding the world in which they will minister, exegeting the Word and the world; e.g., William Carey and A. T. Pierson
- ✓ Interpersonal — emphasizing the importance of relationships, discipleship-oriented implementation, and practical field education
- ✓ Intercession — calling upon God for illumination and needs
- ✓ Integrative — incorporating missiological studies with other academic disciplines
- ✓ Interesting — using methods, processes, and technologies appropriate to the group to enhance interest and student involvement
- ✓ Innovative — utilizing tools available today such as electronic libraries and software systems methodology
- ✓ Interdependent — participating in exchanges, alliances, and partnerships with others involved in the training process; e.g., the annual fellowship gathering of academic deans of evangelical seminaries
- ✓ Internet — using distance learning, e-mail forums, and online delivery systems

- ✓ International — calling for high levels of cultural diversity and a cross-cultural community lifestyle because the gifts of the church belong to the whole church
- ✓ Inclusive — including women
- ✓ Initiative — leading to entrepreneurial risk and spontaneous responsiveness; e.g., YWAM, the largest non-formal training organization and a most significant seedbed for leadership in the Christian movement

The Kinds of Structures That Can Best Support the Push Forward

We live in a networked era, an era that has broken down the ways in which we organize ourselves to get things done. We once were readily defined operational entities that knew who we were and everyone else knew who we were, all within our own operational boundaries. Time and technology has changed all that. In the process of networking, we have discovered the principle that working together across these boundaries has literally exploded as we approach the year 2000. We have discovered that there are a variety of networks, coalitions, partnerships, and movements. Some are embedded in primary unshakable principles and structured partnerships of one sort or other. Some ride the wave of technological advance with e-mail conference networks. Other movements are resource based, seeking to generate and supply greater resources for the task. Some are strategic networks. They seek to advance certain strategic objectives by voluntarily joining together with minimal structure and overhead cost to achieve a multiplying factor toward a common goal.

The role of the local church, the mission agency, and the training institutions as structures to advance the Great Commission is under review as we move into the new millennium.

Discussion with a number of European national leaders, as well as with various church, mission, and school leaders, led to a preliminary consultation on this issue, which was held at Beatenberg Bible School, Switzerland, June 22-24, 1998. The consultation participants expressed their desire to see closer cooperation and partnership between local congregations, training schools, and mission agencies in the task of world evangelization. They called for the re-examination of the role of the church.

We see the need for a theology that recognizes and affirms the importance of the local church in world evangelization, and the complementary roles of local churches, schools, and mission agencies as integral parts of the Church. We see that local congregations should be the senior partners and potential initiators in world evangelization, and that mission agencies should work in a servant role in consultation, education, and mobilization for world evangelization.

The twenty-first century structure will be a success to the degree that it exhibits authenticity, functionality, and flexibility across generations and gender. Authenticity requires that the organization embody its ideals; functionality requires that the organization work; and flexibility requires that the organization be

receptive to the input and suggestions of its members. If these tests are met, the organization will also evidence a high degree of commitment by its members.

Developing an Information System in Response to the Forward Challenges of the Great Commission

A common information system is needed to respond to the various challenges when considering where we go from here in the Great Commission. These challenges include the ideological/religious, the language, the cultural, the geographical, and the urban. A Harvest Information System (HIS) is in development to meet those challenges by providing information on the harvest field, the harvest force, and the harvest yield.

Patrick Johnstone says, "I am delighted with the HIS initiative and fully endorse the need for such. We had to simplify and focus for these three to five years. We should bequeath to the Church of the twenty-first century the full challenge. I believe we now have the attention, interest, and concern of many Christians, and we now also have a commonly agreed set of terms and categorizations to make the complicated analysis more practicable."

The Harvest Field:
ROG - Registry of Geographic Entities
ROH - Registry of Habitats
ROP - Registry of Peoples
ROL - Registry of Languages
ROR - Registry of Religions

The Harvest Force:
ROA - Registry of Agencies
ROM - Registry of Ministries
RON - Registry of Networks
ROS - Registry of Services
RSR – Registry of Scripture Resources

The Harvest Yield:
RMA - Registry of Ministry Assessment
RCA - Registry of Church Adoptions
RPM – Registry of Peoples Ministry
RAC - Registry of Access to Churches

Common Effort

The coordination of a global effort to collect accurate data regarding all peoples is required so those global, continental, national, and local initiatives can work off the same page.

A Common Information System

The development of an information support system is underway through an alliance of Christian entities committed to the stewardship and maintenance of interlinking information sets related to either the harvest field, harvest force, or harvest yield.

A Common Database

The communication of nonsecured, interrelated, user-friendly information through the preparation of a common information database to be distributed by CD-ROM and hard copy is being prepared. Security aspects are handled separately.

Conclusion

We are faced with enormous challenges of many kinds as we move into the twenty-first century. The big question is, where do we go from here with the Great Commission. What do we mean by the Great Commission? How can we be effective in the face of a dramatically changing context? What kinds of structures are needed? What leadership style is appropriate? How do we prepare leaders? What process should be followed to ensure that everybody is involved who needs to be? What kind of information system is needed? These are some of the key questions that need to be addressed as we move to fulfill God's purposes.

For the first time in history, the worldwide body and near-instant interconnective resources are in place to permit a major global advance in working together strategically to advance the cause of Christ throughout the world.

Personal witness is undoubtedly the most effective approach to presenting the gospel. However, we have no way effectively to estimate the extent of availability of the gospel through this means. Neither can a meaningful estimate be made of exposure to the gospel through local church outreach worldwide. But there are some means by which access to the gospel can be measured.

The global broadcast of Billy Graham's world television special on April 14, 1996, to nearly every country in the world exposed more people to the gospel than all his combined audiences in 45 years of ministry. Never before in history had so many people heard the gospel message in a single day.

By the end of the year 2000, eight out of every ten people will have access to the entire Bible in their own language. Nine out of ten will have access to a New Testament. Today the acceleration is so remarkable that more than eighteen different language portions per year are being translated compared to just over three per year in 1900.

Audio communication has been an effective way of communicating the gospel, needed because of the dramatic rates of illiteracy. This technology has emerged as a vital mass medium for reaching an estimated two billion people. This includes all radio and recorded Gospel messages as well as other media that do not require reading skills. By the end of 2000 radio broadcasts are expected to

cover an estimated 99 percent of the world's population and audio gospel recordings will be available to 96 percent.

One of the most effective means of presenting the gospel in visual and audio form has been the Jesus Film. In January of 2000, Paul Eshleman (who leads the AD2000 saturation evangelism track) reported that the number of viewers had increased to 3.3 billion from the 730 million viewers just four years ago. The number of decisions had risen from 42 to 108 million over that same time period.

None of this is to say that all have yet had access to the gospel. We still have a long way to go. But such global advances represent the heart of God. They are already happening. We have many predecessors for our example and inspiration. Praise God! We must sense and catch this vision to cooperate as never before. We must move forward together.

Luis Bush. "Where Do We Go from Here?" In *Mission Handbook 2001-2003*. Wheaton, IL: EMIS, 2000. This chapter used by permission of the Billy Graham Center, Wheaton College, Wheaton, IL 60187-5593. For information about this publication or other resources of the Billy Graham Center, E-mail EMIS@wheaton.edu or visit the web site at: www.wheaton.edu/bgc/emis.